Introduction

A generation which ignores history has no past—and no future.

—Robert Anson Heinlein[*]

This phrase was once recounted to me by my father, a historian. I was just ten years old then and these golden words by Heinlein didn't appear as weighty to me as they do today. My memories are filled with historical anecdotes coated with a syrup of academia. Though my father's library would handsomely showcase the enormous works of stalwarts like S.R. Goel, Sir Jadunath Sarkar and R.C. Majumdar, I never knew that they carried a lot of truth far away from anecdotes I was familiar with. And I never cared to ever ask my father what those books say about our past. My life went on as smoothly as it could, carefree but full of ambition to become something someday so that I could make my parents proud.

As history lessons percolated through me over time, and when I was all set to pursue post-matriculation studies in physics, chemistry and mathematics with the goal of accomplishing just another Bihari dream, that of cracking IIT, it appeared that:

- All invaders except the British were not bad.
- No invaders including the British had any religious zeal.
- Before the arrival of the great invaders, India was the place of all the worst practices like Sati, untouchability, etc.

Despite that (not so) illustrious stint with history at school, there was something at the D.A.V. Public School which sprinkled a few seeds of pride for the nation through a small booklet called *Dharam Shiksha*. The small book told us the tales of the valour of many warriors, freedom fighters who had no mention in the books that were supposed to tell the thing called *history*.[1]

Yet, how could I do away with the *millennial* complex? The book of 'history' was only supposed to *teach* 'history'.

Metaphorically speaking, I was like an *unbaked* pot. The history lessons in books were like adulterated water and interestingly anything going against them was like sterilized water, whose percolation was strictly prohibited.